

“They are Defenseless and Depend on Us to Protect Them”: How Chinese Parents Navigate Privacy for/with Autistic Children

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Abstract

Parents of autistic children constantly balance protecting privacy and sharing diagnoses to seek support. In China, privacy is understood relationally, grounded in social obligation and family “face.” However, this process remains underexplored in Western-focused research. Therefore, we conducted semi-structured interviews with 14 parents of autistic children aged 5-8 to explore how they navigate privacy across home, school, and online contexts. Parents described balancing the desire to protect their children from stigma with the need to build understanding, empathy, and connection within their communities. Disclosure was often partial and strategic, tailored to the audience, the relationship, and anticipated outcomes. Some parents even framed disclosure as a form of advocacy, sharing their stories to foster awareness or help other families. This study contributes a culturally grounded understanding of privacy as a relational moral practice in families with developmental disabilities. We drew implications for mechanisms that support improving privacy awareness, enhancing privacy education, and preserving privacy.

CCS Concepts

• **Security and privacy** → **Human and societal aspects of security and privacy.**

Keywords

Parents; Disclosure; Family and Children; Developmental Disabilities; Culture

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1 Introduction

Parents often serve as privacy stewards in families, balancing children’s safety and autonomy [34, 68]. Their decisions are shaped by children’s developing understanding of abstract privacy concepts [38, 58, 71] and by sociocultural expectations surrounding family responsibility and reputation [27, 29]. However, most existing research has examined these dynamics among neurotypical families, leaving little known about how parents of autistic children, whose digital and social experiences may differ, perceive and protect privacy [27, 29].

Autistic children often encounter misunderstanding and exclusion when their communication styles and behaviors diverge from norms grounded in neurotypical expectations [40, 50]. These social conditions shape distinctive privacy challenges for their families, who must navigate when and how to disclose sensitive information to mitigate stigma and secure necessary support [1, 63]. Families raising autistic children¹ face distinctive privacy challenges.

¹We adopt identity-first language (e.g., “autistic children”) in this paper to align with how many autistic individuals describe themselves and to acknowledge the growing visibility of identity-affirming discourse [15, 61]. At the same time, linguistic norms differ across cultural contexts. In Mandarin Chinese, the distinction between identity-first and person-first expressions is not grammatically salient and has not been a central topic of public or academic debate. Common expressions such as *zìbìzhèng értóng* (自闭症儿童, which can mean either “children with autism” or “autistic children”) and *yǒu zìbì tèzhì de háizi* (有自闭特质的孩子, “children with autistic traits”) are widely used and generally perceived as neutral. Rather than focusing on grammatical form, Chinese-language discourse has centered more on terminology itself, particularly discussions in Mainland China around replacing *zìbìzhèng* (自闭症, literally self-closed disorder) with *gūdúzhèng* (孤独症, “literally loneliness disorder”) as a potentially less stigmatizing label. Our language choice therefore reflects respect for identity-affirming perspectives within English discourse while also acknowledging that Chinese-language communities engage with neurodiversity through different linguistic pathways and evolving cultural conversations.

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Autism-related information, such as diagnostic records or behavioral data, can be deeply personal and often stigmatized [8, 18, 27]. Parents often have to disclose this information to teachers, therapists, or online communities to seek resources, yet such sharing can expose their children to bias, surveillance, or misuse [50, 54, 63].

These dilemmas are further complicated in China, where privacy is understood not only as individual control but also as a relational and moral act tied to family “face” [29, 59]. Parents’ disclosure choices therefore reflect both practical concerns and relational ethics. However, most existing research on autism-related privacy and disclosure has been conducted in Western, Global North contexts, where the neurodiversity paradigm and disability advocacy movements have shaped public discourse [17, 25]. Scholars have recently critiqued this paradigm for its limited attention to diverse sociocultural contexts and epistemologies [42]. Because decisions about disclosure shape help-seeking behavior, access to interventions, and the family’s social identity [60, 69], understanding how Chinese parents navigate privacy is both socially and theoretically important. This study addresses this gap by examining how Chinese parents of autistic children conceptualize and manage privacy in everyday life. We ask:

- RQ1: How do Chinese parents of autistic children conceptualize privacy as influenced by cultural norms, stigma, and moral responsibility?
- RQ2: How do parents manage autism-related information boundaries across home, school, and digital environments, and what factors shape these decisions?
- RQ3: What relational and infrastructural challenges do families face in co-managing privacy with autistic children, and what support systems are needed?

We conducted semi-structured interviews with 14 Chinese parents of autistic children aged 5–8 years (without cognitive impairment). The interviews explored parents’ privacy perceptions, disclosure decisions, and protection strategies across multiple scenarios, including children’s school and home interactions, parents’ engagement with other families, and online information practices.

Our findings reveal that Chinese parents of autistic children conceptualize privacy as a form of moral care. That is a continuous negotiation shaped by stigma, social acceptance, and hopes for their children’s futures. They work to contain autism-related information within systems that are relationally and infrastructurally leaky, and through these daily acts, they affirm their role as capable guardians even when control is uncertain. This paper offers a culturally grounded account of privacy as a relational and moral practice in the context of autism in China. It surfaces the distinctive challenges families face in balancing protection from stigma with the desire for social belonging within schools, neighborhoods, and communities, and it outlines design opportunities for digital tools, educational practices, and community infrastructures that can better support parents’ ongoing privacy work.

2 Related Work

2.1 Children’s Privacy Literacy and Parental Privacy Management

As children’s engagement with digital technologies grows [28, 72], they face a range of privacy risks, including identity exposure, location tracking, and third-party data collection [64]. A key area of

concern is how well children understand privacy and what conceptual limitations shape their awareness and decision-making. Early studies show that children under 11 typically understand privacy as “keeping secrets” or avoiding embarrassment, rather than managing personal data or informed consent [38, 71]. Expanding on this, Sun et al. [58] examined how children conceptualize invisible data processes like tracking and inference. They found that children tend to reason about data in concrete and symbolic ways, relying on surface-level cues (e.g., icons of clouds or loading animations [57]) to make sense of complex data operations. This concrete reasoning limits their understanding of pervasive data flows, third-party access, and long-term inference-based risks that occur beyond their immediate perception [58].

Therefore, in practice, parents often play a central role in managing children’s privacy across both offline and online contexts. Serving as privacy stewards [34], parents balance protection with autonomy. Wisniewski et al. [68] identified two primary strategies: direct parental intervention (e.g., parental controls, monitoring) and active parental mediation (e.g., co-use, discussion, and feedback). While direct intervention can offer safety, it may erode children’s trust and sense of agency [20, 53]. Active mediation supports autonomy but can increase exposure to privacy risks [68]. Moreover, parents also shape children’s digital identities through the information they share online [34]. This stewardship requires not only technical awareness but also moral sensitivity to what constitutes appropriate disclosure in social and digital spaces [2, 41]. However, previous research on this topic has rarely considered families with disabled children, whose technology use often differs in purpose, centering on assistive functions, therapeutic activities, or networked support. These distinctive use contexts introduce additional privacy considerations, as such technologies frequently involve sensitive personal, medical, or behavioral data and greater parental oversight.

2.2 Privacy in Disabled and Autistic Families

Privacy in disabled families, including autistic families, is shaped by technology infrastructures, interdependent care relationships, and social and cultural expectations. Technologies designed to support independence can simultaneously create new forms of privacy violation by reproducing normative expectations of communication (e.g., [21]), reflecting broader tensions between autonomy and safety embedded in sociotechnical systems [66]. These tensions become particularly pronounced in families, where parents serve as both advocates and gatekeepers of privacy for their autistic children.

Courtesy stigma shapes how parents manage privacy, as they are often judged for their child’s behavior or diagnosis [25, 29, 59, 69]. To mitigate social risk while securing essential support, parents carefully regulate diagnostic disclosure. Although sharing an autism diagnosis can facilitate access to services and understanding, it may also expose families to labeling and discrimination [11, 63]. Consequently, parents must determine whether, when, and how to disclose, balancing their child’s informational rights and developmental readiness with the possibility of stigma [1]. While early, supported disclosure can strengthen coping and self-advocacy, delayed communication remains common across developmental disabilities [30]. Clinical communication further shapes these experiences,

as empathetic and clear diagnostic delivery improves parental acceptance and long-term trust [26].

Digital media further complicates privacy negotiations. Social platforms can support advocacy and community-building for autistic individuals and their families [3, 50, 65], but they also increase risks of overexposure and unwanted disclosure. Research shows that autistic teenagers are often cautious about online sharing but remain vulnerable to cyberbullying and social exclusion due to design and social bias [51]. Parents often make disclosure decisions on behalf of their children [54]. This scholarship demonstrates that privacy is continually re-negotiated across shifting social and technological environments. At the same time, neurodiversity scholarship has been predominantly grounded in Global Northern frameworks that marginalize Southern and Indigenous epistemologies [42], leaving limited understandings of how cultural expectations and stigma shape the ways families perform and negotiate privacy in everyday life, including in settings such as China.

2.3 Privacy Management as Performance and Boundary Negotiation

Privacy management in communication is a dynamic process that involves both performance and boundary negotiation in our interactions with others. To interpret how Chinese parents of autistic children navigate privacy, we draw on insights from Goffman's Dramaturgy [24] and Communication Privacy Management theory [47, 48]. Goffman's Dramaturgical perspective [24] conceptualizes social life as a continuous performance in which people strategically manage impressions before various audiences. These performances are structured by context: *frontstage* interactions involve conforming to expected norms, whereas *backstage* spaces allow more authentic expressions of self, away from judgment and scrutiny. Identity, in this view, is not a fixed possession but an accomplishment, sustained through the management of impressions, emotions, and social cues. Although Goffman did not propose a formal "privacy theory," his dramaturgical model implicitly addresses privacy as the management of boundaries between what is revealed and what is concealed to maintain a desired impression. Crucially, the maintenance of privacy in social life is a cooperative endeavor. It is sustained through boundary-regulating social norms, such as "tactful inattention," the shared understanding that others will politely ignore what is not meant for them. However, these norms, and the degree of "effective privacy" they afford, vary across cultural and social contexts. Building on this framework, prior studies show that individuals and families perform carefully differentiated roles to negotiate stigma and sustain normalcy in the face of illness, disability, and mental distress [13, 25].

Communication Privacy Management theory complements this performance-based account by focusing on the management of private information. Petronio conceptualizes privacy as the drawing and redrawing of metaphorical boundaries that separate personal knowledge from public exposure [47, 48]. Communication Privacy Management theory identifies several key mechanisms in this process: *boundary linkage* (who is brought into the privacy circle), *boundary ownership* (the rights and responsibilities of co-owners), and *boundary permeability* (how open or closed the boundary is).

Privacy is always negotiated, shaped by competing goals and contextual considerations. Individuals must continually weigh the benefits of disclosure (e.g., building trust or receiving support) against its potential risks (e.g., judgment, loss of control). Once shared, private information is subject to collective stewardship, and violations of expectations, known as *boundary turbulence* [46], can prompt renegotiations of trust, control, and communicative rules [27, 49]. Together, Goffman's Dramaturgy [24] and Communication Privacy Management theory [47, 48] frame privacy as a socially embedded, culturally mediated, and dynamically negotiated process [9]. It is practiced not only as a defensive mechanism but also as a culturally shaped performance and form of relational labor, especially in contexts of stigma, caregiving, and moral scrutiny [13, 25, 49].

2.4 Face, Social Belonging, and Privacy in China

Face and Collective Reputation. Face (面子) in Chinese culture refers to publicly recognized dignity, prestige, and moral legitimacy [10]. Drawing on Goffman's concept of face-work [23, 24], individuals perform appropriate roles to align with social expectations and maintain harmonious interaction. However, in China, face extends beyond the individual. One person's behavior reflects the reputation of their entire family and relational circle. Losing face thus produces not only personal embarrassment but also collective shame and a potential withdrawal of social support [10, 29]. Protecting face becomes a mechanism for safeguarding a family's social standing and access to resources.

Confucian Virtue and Guanxi Formation. In high-context cultures, including China, a person's identity, communication, and expectations are embedded in longstanding relational networks, such as extended family, lineage, and neighborhood communities [52]. These networks offer security and support but also impose social obligations [32]. In China, face-work is further guided by Confucian ethics, which emphasize propriety, reciprocity, and the fulfillment of relational roles. Demonstrating virtue sustains *guanxi* (关系) networks. Relationships deepen through mutual care, role fulfillment, and reputation protection, forming the basis of trust and social survival [10]. *Guanxi* capital is earned by acting in ways that affirm others' dignity and reinforce one's reliability within the network. Failure to uphold these responsibilities risks damaging trust and diminishing access to future opportunities. In this relational moral economy, impression management is not solely self-oriented; it is a protective practice that maintains interdependence and preserves the family's rightful place within social hierarchies.

Collectivism and Social Belonging. These dynamics are embedded in a broader collectivist worldview in which identity is constituted through relationships rather than individual autonomy [52]. *Guanxi* ties, rooted in kinship, lineage, and neighborly communities, shape a person's access to belonging, support, and social mobility. To be seen as a "proper" group member is to behave in ways consistent with collective expectations for deference, restraint, and harmony. Belonging is thus a conditional and continually negotiated state, maintained through ongoing performance of relational accountability [10].

Across these literatures, two gaps emerge: (1) a focus on Western autonomy-centered privacy models and (2) limited attention to disability and cultural stigma in shaping parental mediation. We

respond by examining how Chinese parents of autistic children perform privacy as a negotiation of relational obligations, reputation, and safety.

3 Method

We conducted semi-structured remote interviews with 14 Chinese parents whose children were diagnosed with autism to explore their perceptions of privacy and privacy risks, protection strategies, as well as challenges and potential solutions. The study recruitment and study protocol were approved by Duke Kunshan University's institutional review board (IRB).

3.1 Participants

Fourteen parents of autistic children (see their demographics info in Table 1), including two fathers and twelve mothers, were recruited from one of the largest special education schools for autistic children and adolescents in China through a convenience sampling method. All of their children were boys, aged between 5 and 8 years old. We sent a recruitment poster to teachers at the aforementioned school, which covered a brief description of the study topic and a QR code that provided access to a registration form. Parents who were interested scanned the QR code on the poster and submitted their basic demographic information to register their participation. We reached out to these parents and set up the interview date and time. All participants received 100 CNY as compensation for their time participating in the interview.

All participants were from different families. Half of the 14 participants had children who completed their intervention program at the special education school and were back in regular kindergartens ($n=3$) or elementary schools ($n=4$). The other half of the parents' ($n=7$) children were still attending the intervention programs in the special education school at the time they were interviewed. All participants were from China and spoke Mandarin, and the interviews were all conducted in Mandarin. Each interview lasted approximately 60–80 minutes and was audio-recorded only after obtaining participants' explicit consent.

The special education school has varying levels of departments and classes according to children's ages, cognitive abilities, and disorders, which had provided interventions for more than 8,000 autistic children by the time of recruitment. All of our participants' children were from the "Integration Department", which specialized in teaching autistic children (without cognitive impairment) between the ages of 5 and 8 with the physical, emotional, and social skills needed for participating in regular kindergartens.

3.2 Study Procedure

Before the study began, we explained the research purpose and procedures to the parents and obtained informed consent. We then scheduled interview sessions and sent participants a meeting invitation link. All interviews were conducted remotely through the VooV Meeting app².

At the beginning of each interview, we reminded participants that their participation was voluntary, that they could skip any questions they did not wish to answer, and that they could end the

interview at any time without giving any reason. We then began with warm-up questions collecting participants' demographics, including their children's age, gender, and education background, and challenges encountered raising autistic children. Next, we prompted participants with five contexts to facilitate the conversation and understand their perceptions of privacy, risk concerns, and privacy protection strategies. Specifically, questions about these five contexts covered their family life, their children's school life, information searching and sharing, communication with others about autism-related information, and their children's online/in-person social activities with others. The order of questions being asked was adjusted according to participants' responses in the conversation flow. One thing to note, the interviewer did not initially mention the word "privacy" during the interview unless participants began to use it, leaving more open-ended discussion for participants to share their understanding and perception of privacy. Finally, we asked participants about our research topic (i.e., privacy) and to elaborate on their thoughts about it. See Appendix A for our interview guide.

3.3 Data Analysis

All participants agreed to be audio-recorded except one (P14). We first transcribed the recordings using the transcription service provided by the VooV Meeting software. Then, we reviewed and corrected the transcripts to maintain consistency with the audio recordings. At least two of the authors participated in all interviews, one being the interviewer and the others taking notes. We performed qualitative content analysis in Mandarin on the transcribed interview transcripts through a systematic process of coding and identifying themes. The coding analysis was completed in two phases. First, four coders (the authors) carefully reviewed all interview transcripts and collaboratively selected one transcript (P6) that all coders agreed covered the broadest range of meaningful patterns. Three coders then independently generated initial codes from this transcript, after which they met to discuss all codes and reached consensus on a preliminary codebook. Next, the four coders were randomly assigned to code the remaining transcripts using this codebook. Each transcript was independently coded by two coders, who then met to compare and discuss their codes. When conflicts arose, each coder explained their rationale, and unresolved disagreements were brought to the entire research team for discussion until consensus was reached. Eventually, they reached a consensus and consolidated the final list of codes. Four coders then discussed and categorized codes together into themes. In total, 451 codes were generated, which we synthesized into three themes: (1) privacy as a form of moral care shaped by stigma and belonging, (2) privacy as difficult to control due to infrastructural and relational vulnerabilities, and (3) privacy as ongoing work enacted through everyday strategies and *in situ* learning within families.

4 Results

Parents defined privacy as a moral responsibility, struggled to uphold it amid infrastructural and relational leaks, and developed adaptive strategies and educational efforts to sustain it. To preserve participants' voices while minimizing researcher bias, we include translated excerpts from participants' original Chinese statements, edited lightly for clarity and brevity.

²Similarly to Zoom, VooV Meeting (腾讯会议) is an online conferencing software that allows users to join on mobile phones, PCs, tablets, and webpages.

ID	Parents' Gender	Parents' Employment Status	Children's Gender	Children's Age (years)	Children's Education
P1	Female	Full-time Childcare	Male	5	Kindergarten
P2	Female	Full-time Childcare	Male	6	Special Education School
P3	Female	Full-time Childcare	Male	5	Kindergarten
P4	Female	N/A	Male	5	Kindergarten
P5	Female	Full-time Childcare	Male	5	Special Education School
P6	Female	N/A	Male	8	Elementary School
P7	Female	N/A	Male	8	Elementary School
P8	Female	N/A	Male	8	Elementary School
P9	Female	Full-time Childcare	Male	5	Special Education School
P10	Male	Full-time Childcare	Male	6	Special Education School
P11	Female	Full-time Childcare	Male	6	Special Education School
P12	Female	Full-time Childcare	Male	6	Special Education School
P13	Male	N/A	Male	6	Special Education School
P14	Female	N/A	Male	8	Elementary School

Table 1: Participants' demographic information, including both parents' gender and employment status and children's age, gender, and education background.

4.1 Privacy as Moral Care: Weighing Stigma, Access, and Altruism

4.1.1 Privacy as Relational Responsibility. Parents (n=13) consistently drew a moral boundary between ordinary data and autism-related information. Personal details such as phone numbers or browsing histories were considered trivial, while information that could reveal or imply a diagnosis, such as special-education records, therapy attendance, or behavioral descriptions, was viewed as socially sensitive because it could invite stigma or exclusion. Privacy, therefore, was not understood as individual control but as a relational duty of care. While their own data were “ordinary”, parents believed their child's information required ongoing protection to preserve dignity and future opportunities. This responsibility was heightened by perceptions that autistic children could not manage privacy independently:

“Children who are high-functioning or have Asperger's may be easily targeted if they work and live alone, because they are very, very innocent and defenseless. They need to depend on their parents to protect them. For people like my son, I will never let him face these privacy issues alone because I know they could not successfully defend themselves.” (P13)

Parents saw themselves as ongoing guardians of their children's privacy, especially given communication and social challenges that could make self-protection difficult.

4.1.2 Avoiding Stigma and Institutional Permanence. Most parents (n=6) feared that disclosing a diagnosis could lead to discrimination from schools, neighbors, or employers. Many (n=9) withheld diagnostic information even when doing so might limit access to support:

“I hope teachers can help, but once they know, they may treat him differently.” (P4)

For many, non-disclosure was a way to secure a fair starting point. This sense of duty was intensified by China's bureaucratic information systems. Several parents worried that a disability certificate or special-education record would be stored in the child's Dang'an³, the lifelong citizen file that influences education and employment opportunities. As one parent explained:

“There are government-issued allowances for people with disabilities in every city. If our kid joins the special education program, we will be eligible to apply for these programs from the China Disabled Persons' Federation (CDPF) and receive a disability certificate. However, my husband would not apply because his friends keep asking him, ‘If you apply, is it going to be in the child's personal profile and follow your child for the rest of his/her life? Is it going to impact the child's future?’ We would never know, and maybe it's the fear that people will treat our child differently when they see his/her Dang'an.” (P11)

Consequently, some families chose not to apply for official recognition or government allowances, prioritizing long-term social mobility over short-term benefits. For these parents, privacy was not a one-time decision about whether to disclose, but a concern about what disclosure might set in motion once it became institutionally permanent. Once disclosed, the label of autism could persist beyond their control.

4.1.3 Balancing Access and Opportunity. When revealing information could directly improve their child's development, a few parents (n=4) viewed selective disclosure as a pragmatic necessity. As P4 explained, she prioritized her child's social learning and adaptation to mainstream environments over “keep everything secret”. Many parents turned to online spaces, such as Baidu, Weibo, and WeChat,

³Citizen's profile, or Dang'an (档案) in Mandarin, is a public record used in China as a permanent archive or filing system to record the “performance and history” of mainland Chinese citizens [67]. Dang'an is widely used when citizens are looking for education and employment opportunities.

to seek advice that formal systems failed to provide. Consistent with prior research on networked support [3, 4], these platforms filled crucial gaps in health and education but also created new privacy risks. Search histories, group names, and public-account subscriptions could inadvertently reveal a diagnosis. Parents recognized these exposures yet often accepted them as a necessary trade-off, a calculated compromise between gaining knowledge and maintaining control. For them, disclosure was not a moral failure but an ethical balancing act, navigating between protection and opportunity in a system where support and stigma remained deeply intertwined.

4.1.4 Altruistic Disclosure as Moral Care. Although few parents disclosed their own child’s diagnosis publicly, many admired others who did (e.g., P8, P12, P13). All parents (n=14) mentioned learning from peers who shared their children’s stories on social media. Parents who spoke openly were praised as selfless and inspiring:

“He (a parent on social media) shares his family’s experiences to give us more confidence as parents. So even though he sacrificed some of his own child’s privacy related to his autism conditions, he helps everyone like us and has been appreciated by everyone.” (P8)

This openness was framed as “sacrifice” and moral “giving”, a collectivist act that prioritizes community benefit over individual protection. They framed these parents as courageous and altruistic role models. However, the “success stories” they celebrated often featured children who were “high-functioning” or whose autistic traits had become less visible. As P13 observed, disclosure “has less negative impact” because their child’s conditions had already “become mild”. Such narratives suggest that disclosure tends to feel safer when difference appears manageable or when the individual can more easily perform neurotypical norms. A widely cited example was a school founder whose autistic son was now married and successful. As P12 explained, “He’s too excellent to be affected by the word autism”. This admiration for positive stories reveals a deeper paradox. Parents viewed disclosure as stigmatizing, yet such narratives often reinforced a hierarchy of acceptability that privileges “manageable” forms of autism over those that appear more visibly different. In this sense, moral disclosure both challenges and reproduces stigma.

4.2 Privacy Beyond Control: Infrastructural and Relational Vulnerabilities

Even as parents defined privacy as a moral duty, they found it increasingly difficult to uphold. Rather than a matter of individual carelessness, disclosure often emerged through uncontrollable, unpredictable, and opaque processes from algorithmic data collection to casual social interactions.

4.2.1 External Channels of Involuntary Disclosure. Parents (n=11) described a constant tension between seeking help and exposing sensitive data. Searching for autism-related information through Baidu, Weibo, or WeChat often generated new forms of digital traceability. Five parents reported receiving targeted advertisements or phone calls from autism programs immediately after searching online, which reinforced their sense that digital systems were tracking their needs:

“Because you won’t search for autistic children-related information if you don’t have any needs, right?” (P10)

WeChat support groups presented similar dilemmas. Interestingly, most parents (n=11) joined group chats organized by schools or educators, sometimes with hundreds of members. These groups provided valuable peer advice but often required real-name registration (e.g., *child’s name + father/mother + region + child’s date of birth*), inadvertently linking personal and diagnostic information. As one parent explained:

“In the large WeChat group that [the name of the special education school] organizes, I certainly won’t tell any details about my child. If other people’s questions are not urgent, generally I will not respond.” (P9)

Many participants thus adopted pseudonyms or remained silent, recognizing that the very infrastructures enabling support also amplified exposure.

Finally, disclosure often occurred within offline relational networks such as relatives, neighbors, or community workers. For many families, privacy was not managed by a single individual but negotiated within the household, where different members held unequal understandings of what should be kept private. Several mothers (n=8) noted that their child’s diagnosis became known in the neighborhood because their partner or grandparents had mentioned it in casual conversation. In contemporary Chinese families, grandparents frequently provide daily childcare while both parents work full-time, yet they often lack awareness of the social consequences of disclosure. As one participant explained, older family members tended to share information about the child’s condition without realizing its sensitivity. This gap in privacy norms within the same household revealed that privacy, though framed as a collective moral duty, was enacted inconsistently across family members.

Beyond the family, parents (n=6) also reported that social familiarity in neighborhoods and community service centers made concealment difficult. For instance, P11 described how a local staff member publicly asked about her child’s disability certificate when applying for an allowance:

“When my husband went to the neighborhood community center to apply for an allowance from a local assistance program at the end of last year, a staff member asked publicly and loudly, ‘Do you have a disability certificate for your child?’ Other people in the community center may already know each other; when they overheard this question and conversation, they would learn about my child’s autism condition. That way, the fact that my child has autism might be spread among our neighbors.” (P11)

These everyday interactions show how even well-intentioned family or community actions can turn privacy into a shared but unstable responsibility, constantly at risk of unintended exposure.

4.2.2 Child-Related Factors Limiting Privacy Protection. Parents also viewed their children’s social and cognitive profiles as barriers to privacy management. Consistent with prior research [31], autistic children often struggled to interpret social norms or recognize the

sensitivity of personal information. Several parents described how their children unintentionally shared identifying details:

“We didn’t tell the teachers about his autism condition, but the teacher later learned about it from him. He told them (the teachers and other classmates at the new school) everything, like which school he had attended, who he had met, and where he had been. He also asked other kids in his class the same questions.” (P8)

Others noted that their children lacked a clear sense of boundaries and could both lose their own privacy and inadvertently invade others’. P13 provided an example that happened at the special education school, where one of his son’s classmates (who was also an autistic child) would always open the restroom door. Parents interpreted these incidents as evidence that privacy for autistic children is not an individual competence but a collective task shared between family and institutions.

Nevertheless, even vigilant guardianship had limits. Parents acknowledged that some aspects of autism, such as stimming behaviors, speech patterns, or gestures, made privacy impossible to fully protect:

“Even though I don’t admit that he (P7’s son) is autistic, people can tell by observing him in the outside world.” (P7)

When recognition was unavoidable, parents could only prepare their children to face bias (P12) or hope for broader understanding (P4). Despite their vigilance, privacy often slipped beyond their control through opaque and asymmetric systems that determined how information moved and was interpreted. Once disclosed, even unintentionally, a diagnosis could circulate and persist in ways no parent could predict or retract. Concealment thus became a moral strategy of care. Parents withheld information to resist structural stigma and the permanence of bureaucratic labeling. On the other hand, it expressed a desire for conditional belonging, a hope that by keeping difference unseen, their family could remain recognizable as “normal”. In this tension, privacy became both protection and compliance. A relational survival strategy balances resistance to stigma with aspiration for social acceptance.

4.3 Managing Privacy: Family Strategies and Everyday Adaptations

Rather than seeking full control, parents sought workable containment, such as practical strategies to reduce recognition and retain some control over how autism-related information appeared in daily life.

4.3.1 Tactical Regulation: Parents’ Everyday Practices. Parents described experimenting with small, often improvised tactics to limit data collection and exposure. Some restricted app permissions, disabled tracking features (n=4), or used “incognito” browsing modes (P4) when searching autism-related information, believing these steps could deter surveillance. Although such practices offered limited protection compared to tools like Tor [56], they reflected parents’ willingness to act despite low trust in digital infrastructures:

“These (privacy) settings and terms are only for show [...] If the company wants to access my location information, they can do so anytime, and I won’t tell.” (P13)

Even though these practices provided limited technical protection, they gave parents a sense of agency in the face of digital systems they perceived as opaque and a social environment where autism could lead to stigma.

Online sharing practices followed similar logics of selective visibility. Some (n=3) avoided sharing children’s names or identifiable details in large social groups, while others (n=6) remained silent altogether. To protect their children, parents used pseudonyms (n=2) or removed all identifying information (n=3) when sharing stories. P10 explained that he would “only describe situations, never names or details.” Two others “shared completely anonymously”, often by creating new accounts:

“If I am going to share something online [...] I would first register for a new WeChat account. I would try to avoid adding other parents, our friends, and relatives who we know to this new account and build a brand new friend circle, where no one knows who I am or what I do. Then, I would be comfortable sharing some of our experiences.” (P8)

Some parents (n=5) chose not to disclose their child’s diagnosis even to the child, believing that withholding such information prevented accidental disclosure:

“Until today, I’ve never told him about the time when he couldn’t speak. Although he remembers that he used to go to, like, a special education school, he didn’t know what they were for and just thought he was at a regular school. It was my way to protect his privacy.” (P7)

Interestingly, several parents (n=6) perceived proximity as risky. They feared gossip within close social or geographic circles and felt safer disclosing details to people from other regions, such as teachers or parents they would not meet again. For instance, P7 explained to us that she preferred to communicate and share more details with teachers who came from other cities since it was less likely for them to see each other again in the future and to know each other’s social circles. As P12 put it, “Sharing with people we’ll never meet again increases anonymity.”

4.3.2 Teaching Privacy Through Everyday Interactions. For many parents, teaching children about privacy was part of their ongoing work of care to protect dignity, manage stigma, and act as capable guardians in an uncertain social environment. Around half (n=6) said their children received privacy lessons at school, mostly about bodily boundaries. Teachers used short videos or role-playing games to help children learn when to refuse inappropriate requests.

“In the class, the teacher will simulate a scenario(s). The teacher would pretend to be a stranger and ask the children questions like, ‘What color is your underwear?’, ‘Show me your underwear,’ ‘Do your breast areas feel uncomfortable? Let me touch them and help you.’ The teachers will ask the children to assume how they would respond if they were in these situations, and teach them what to do if the children give improper answers.” (P2)

Parents valued these lessons but often described them as limited. Some (n=5) indicated that these privacy education classes were often only offered to autistic children without cognitive impairment because school teachers considered them to be more capable of understanding privacy education. Some only received privacy education through prerecorded online classes.

“We, as parents, may lack understanding of the purposes of these online courses (about privacy education), and we can’t guarantee to always show them the privacy education lecture videos. Every time my son’s school releases these online classes, my son might just click on things on my phone pretty quickly, and I think he didn’t learn anything at the end of the day.” (P6)

Parents, therefore, took on the role of privacy guides themselves. They wanted privacy education to be concrete and continuous, built into the routines of daily life. P6 suggested that families and schools should learn together, noting that parents often act in the moment when risks arise.

“It would definitely improve privacy education if we could have both classroom lectures and real-world practices through multiple modalities. That’s definitely better (in improving children’s privacy literacy and awareness). Moreover, the guidance and assistance from us (the parents or guardians) in privacy education are also very important, and we usually know very little about it, especially when risky situations happen. So we should also be engaged in these classes or related education programs.” (P6)

Many parents (n=8) described guiding their children in real time. These brief in-the-moment directions, such as gentle corrections in elevators, classrooms, or parks, became moments where parental identity and moral responsibility were performed.

“Once when we took the elevator and he wanted to introduce his name and the primary school he was studying in with a stranger, I would say, ‘They are not interested in this, but you can whisper it to mommy.’ Then, I told him, ‘You have to keep information about yourself as your secret and don’t show it to others’. Then, sometimes, I would ask him to show me, and he would say, ‘No, no, this is my privacy!’” (P1)

P1 further explained that she would repeatedly offer similar in-the-moment guidance in everyday situations. Over time, her son came to understand that he should keep “his secrets” to his family members, even without deliberate or structured practice. In another example, P4 noted that by consistently providing guidance right after incidents involving potential privacy leakage, her son gradually learned what should be considered private information and began refusing others’ requests for such information. These interventions were not planned lessons but responsive acts of care. Parents corrected their children in the moment when they sensed risk. Over time, children began to use their parents’ language of “secrets” or “my privacy”, which parents viewed as small signs of progress. Such practices reassured them that they could still protect and prepare their children even amid uncertainty about future social encounters. Privacy learning in this context was continuous, relational, and

emotionally charged, forming a routine part of caregiving rather than a separate educational task.

5 Discussion

This study examined how Chinese parents of autistic children perceive, negotiate, and act upon privacy across home, school, and digital settings. Through in-depth interviews, we found that parents confront constant privacy risks while also depending on information sharing to access support, resources, and social understanding for their children. Parents believe autism reshapes privacy work because privacy norms rely heavily on implicit social rules and contextual cues that digital and institutional systems often fail to make accessible. This situates parents as continuous mediators, translating opaque privacy environments, anticipating risks, and managing information flows on their children’s behalf.

Across accounts, privacy is not a static right or a configurable setting but an ongoing form of care work that enables families to maintain dignity and participate in social life. In high-context collectivist environments, social legitimacy depends on smooth *frontstage* performances and mutual efforts to maintain face [52]. Autism disrupts these expectations, not only because autistic children may communicate or behave in ways that diverge from unspoken expectations, but also because dominant privacy norms presume shared, implicit understandings of what should or should not be disclosed. Parents thus fear that others may interpret such moments as threats to social harmony or failures in family responsibility, revealing how stigma and structural ableism shape privacy demands.

Our findings advance the field’s understanding of privacy by illuminating how relational privacy dynamics are shaped through disability and caregiving. By foregrounding autism-related privacy in China from parents’ perspectives, we contribute a culturally grounded account of how disability amplifies the stakes and complexity of privacy boundary negotiation in collectivist, high-context societies. Our analysis expands theoretical discussions of privacy as relational and contextual by demonstrating that access to privacy is itself unevenly distributed and deeply tied to broader projects of care, belonging, and survival. In the following sections, we further develop these insights to refine theories of privacy stewardship and boundary management, and to inform the design of privacy-supportive systems that acknowledge interdependence and care as fundamental to human experience.

5.1 Care-Based Privacy Stewardship in Families with Autistic Children

Our findings show that parents assume the primary responsibility for mediating privacy across home, school, and digital environments. While prior work has described parents broadly as “privacy stewards” who identify risks, teach protective strategies, and manage information flows [53], the parents of autistic children in China engage in sustained and proactive stewardship driven by care, advocacy, and concerns for long-term well-being. This heightened vigilance emerges from the social and infrastructural conditions surrounding autism. As extant research notes, neurotypical children gain familiarity with privacy rules and develop self-protection skills over time [38, 71]. However, when privacy expectations rely on reading subtle social cues or inferring unwritten rules, autistic

children are structurally excluded from the knowledge needed to participate fully in privacy decision-making. Consequently, parents take on continuous work to anticipate potential risks and to negotiate protective practices in contexts such as school communication or interactions in public spaces.

This stewardship intensifies in digital environments, where the scope and permanence of information flows amplify parents' protective concerns. As shown in Section 4.2.1, parents worried that information shared in WeChat groups, online parent communities, or school communication channels could be seen, forwarded, or discussed by others in ways they could neither anticipate nor control. In response, parents engaged in privacy-protective practices grounded in intuitive reasoning about how digital systems might track or store information. For example, some restricted app permissions, disabled location tracking, or used private browsing modes when searching for autism-related information (see Section 4.3.1). These strategies provided a sense of agency, even as parents acknowledged that digital infrastructures remained largely opaque and difficult to control. Yet this perceived protection often exceeded actual safeguards: while private browsing mode prevents local device-level history from being stored, it does not prevent data collection by service providers or platforms [56]. This gap underscores that privacy stewardship in these families is guided primarily by care and vigilance rather than comprehensive technical knowledge.

Beyond these immediate protective measures, parents' concerns extended to longer-term consequences that transcend interpersonal harm or momentary embarrassment. Parents worry that digital traces, such as disability certification records and online consultation histories, may result in persistent, institutionalized forms of marginalization. We characterize this shift as a transformation from situational stigma to datafied stigma: a stigmatizing force embedded in algorithms, bureaucratic infrastructures, and long-term data retention that can shape their children's future opportunities in education, employment, and social participation.

5.2 How Culture Shapes Family Boundary Practices

Parents' privacy decisions were structured by cultural expectations of collective well-being and relational responsibility. We show how audience and culture jointly structure parents' *frontstage/backstage* disclosure strategies [24], and how coordination failures produce boundary conflicts [47, 48] with children and other family members, who may not recognize the cultural and relational consequences of information disclosure.

5.2.1 Cultural dramaturgy: frontstage/backstage driven by face. Prior work shows that individuals strategically manage self-presentation based on audience and setting [24]. Extending this dramaturgical perspective to Chinese families, our findings show that parents of autistic children conceal diagnosis-related information in public *frontstage* contexts to avoid stigma and preserve social acceptance (see Section 4.1.2). Such protective withholding reflects a core cultural belief: in collectivist societies, individuals are closely identified with their family unit, and their conduct reflects the family's character and influences its social standing [14]. Therefore, disclosing

autism risks not only reveals personal information but also jeopardizes collective face and the family's social standing.

This face-driven privacy work reflects a culturally embedded pursuit of social membership, an everyday strategy for preserving dignity and claiming participation in systems that inadequately accommodate neurodivergence. In our findings, parents expressed strong reluctance to reveal autism-related details when interacting with unfamiliar audiences in public or large WeChat groups, fearing discrimination or long-term exclusion (see Section 4.2.1). However, willingness to share seems to increase when the risk of "losing face" diminishes. For example, participants observed that parents who publicly shared their children's autism stories did so under conditions that minimized risk (e.g., when their children appeared "high-functioning" or when success narratives reduced perceived stigma), making disclosure morally acceptable and even admirable (see Section 4.1.4). Similarly, spatial and relational distance afforded by online peer groups or geographically distant audiences created partial anonymity (see Section 4.3.1), allowing parents to temporarily detach from the social gaze of their offline identities and engage in more candid disclosure.

In both examples, reduced recognition risk seems to facilitate more open discussion of diagnosis, behavioral challenges, and treatment strategies. This audience-sensitive boundary management aligns with communication research showing that contextual factors shape disclosure practices [48], illustrating how parents actively distinguish what can be shown frontstage versus backstage.

5.2.2 Communication Boundary Management in a collectivist family system: co-owned privacy and boundary. Communication Boundary Management theory emphasizes that privacy boundaries involving others must be co-managed [47, 48]. According to this theory, parents and their autistic children share a collective privacy boundary [48] when parents share family private information with their children, such as bank accounts, phone numbers, home addresses, and the children's autistic conditions.

However, our findings reveal challenges in establishing these collective boundaries. For instance, parents reported that autistic children often share sensitive information without understanding why they should not (see Section 4.2.2). These coordination failures stem from two factors. First, autistic children have difficulties in grasping abstract concepts [45], and privacy is considered abstract, especially for children [33, 44, 55]. Second, autistic children lack strong abilities in recognizing social cues, understanding social norms, and adjusting behaviors based on context [7, 16, 19], making it difficult for them to understand what counts as private, recognize potential risks, and apply privacy-protective behaviors. Parents' own lack of privacy education and literacy further compounds these difficulties.

These coordination challenges even extend beyond parent-child relationships. Family members held different understandings of what information should be kept private and how to disclose their children's conditions, leading to uneven and sometimes unintended disclosure (see Section 4.2.1). Without mutually agreed-upon rules, such unintended disclosures created "boundary turbulence" that parents experienced as threats to both privacy and face, aligning with Communication Boundary Management's predictions regarding coordination failures [48].

Together, these findings demonstrate how Communication Privacy Management theory [48] and Goffman’s Dramaturgical theory [24] manifest in collectivist contexts, where privacy management and impression management are collective moral responsibilities embedded within family reputation rather than individual autonomy. Frontstage boundaries are therefore co-constructed to preserve collective face, while backstage disclosure becomes a relational coping strategy that enables parents to reclaim support and belonging. We argue that privacy research must move beyond Western individualist assumptions to recognize how collectivist family systems prioritize family identity over individual autonomy in privacy boundary decisions.

5.3 Cultural Trade-offs Between Protection and Belonging

In China, where autism awareness has grown in recent years yet public understanding and institutional support remain uneven [60, 69], families navigate complex social expectations around disability disclosure. A diagnosis can be interpreted as hereditary failure or familial inadequacy [59], and parents may fear that recognition of disability will disrupt the family’s *guanxi* networks and expose them to gossip or exclusion from educational and community resources [29]. Thus, privacy emerges as a strategy of collective protection (see Section 4.1): limiting disclosure helps preserve dignity, avoid stigma, and maintain the relational foundations of belonging. For these families, privacy is not simply about controlling personal information; it is a moral practice of safeguarding the family’s face, trustworthiness, and future possibilities within the social collective.

5.3.1 Privacy as a lower priority under survival and caregiving pressure. Similar to Just and Berg’s findings [63], many parents from our interviews express concerns about the potential negative consequences if they disclose their children’s privacy, particularly autism-related information (see Section 4.1.2). However, some of our participants thought privacy protection and privacy education were secondary to the benefits of disclosing information. In some cases, parents share some children’s diagnosis in exchange for developing their social skills (see Section 4.1.3). As described in Section 4.1.4, parents generally hold a positive attitude when other parents share experiences of their autistic children online and publicly, considering it to be altruism. Our participants all perceived such behaviors to be beneficial and to help the interests of the collective autistic community, regardless of the fact that such behaviors will leak other children’s privacy. One other possible reason for the lower level of priority of privacy may be that families with autism in China do not receive adequate help and services, compared with neurotypical children, from the entire society [59] for their children’s education and employment. Thus, some parents might be driven to self-disclose their children’s privacy in exchange for psychological, financial, and behavioral support from school teachers, relatives, neighbors, and community organizations.

5.3.2 Social media as a collective backstage to rebuild belonging. Earlier work reported that Western parents of children with special needs primarily visited online social groups (e.g., Facebook pages and groups, Yahoo! groups) to access information and receive social supports [3, 4]. Some parents also used throwaway accounts on

Reddit to discuss stigmatized topics [5]. Interestingly, researchers identified that the use of throwaway accounts facilitated users’ engagement in discussing the stigmatized topics anonymously. Therefore, the use of social media can empower various marginalized communities, which transformed users from passive information recipients to active information producers [3]. Similarly, our study results demonstrate that parents also received support and help from online social groups in WeChat (they usually do not have access to the aforementioned social media sites, like Reddit; also, not many of them understand English) and in-person gatherings with members from the autism community for parenting strategies and learning other children’s developmental stories. However, few parents from our study have shared their private information before due to concerns of potential short- and long-term consequences to their children. Some parents expressed their willingness to share only under anonymous situations. Future research could investigate privacy-preserving methods that can offer a safe online space for parents of children with special needs to seek and share information.

5.3.3 Cultural double bind of disclosure in public society. While parents in our study did not always articulate this explicitly, our analysis infers that choosing to limit disclosure could be socially read as signaling shame or insufficient acceptance of the child. This interpretation aligns with prior work showing that Chinese caregivers often conceal diagnoses to avoid stigma and loss of face in social contexts [43]. In this moralized caregiving context, non-disclosure is evaluated not merely as a boundary preference but as a potentially stigmatizing act, making refusal to disclose socially risky. Consequently, parents face a double bind. They wish to prevent others from speaking about their child’s diagnosis, yet explicitly prohibiting such talk may also invite negative judgment. They must therefore manage privacy without openly asserting it, further complicating boundary coordination with family members and peers.

5.4 Implications for Future App Features and Privacy Education

Finally, our findings contribute to broader HCI conversations on design justice and critical disability design. Parents’ privacy practices reflect not only protection from harm but also aspirations for their children’s social participation and dignity. Designing systems that redistribute control to autistic users and their caregivers, rather than reinforcing deficit-based interventions, can support more equitable and empowering privacy futures.

5.4.1 Anonymous sharing on social media. The parents in our study mainly used existing messaging tools or platforms widely used in China (e.g., WeChat groups and public accounts) to communicate with schools and teachers, exchange experiences with other parents, and seek social support (see Section 4.1.3). However, these platforms often require real-name or ID-based registration, which can lead to involuntary disclosures (see Section 4.2.1). For example, posting or re-posting content may require linking a national ID number, making it difficult to create throwaway accounts as one might on platforms such as Reddit. Even when display names are pseudonymous, parents remain cautious when discussing sensitive

topics, concerned that their children could still be identified, stigmatized, or treated differently. These tensions highlight opportunities for researchers and designers of social networking tools and autism-related support apps to develop privacy-preserving communication features that enable parents to share and seek support without compromising anonymity.

5.4.2 In-situ privacy education for autistic children. Prior work demonstrates different privacy education approaches to increase privacy literacy through social media apps [35], games and stories [36], or frameworks based on contextual integrity [6]. Kumar et al. argued that privacy literacy education should focus on conveying concrete privacy norms and contexts (e.g., “only share your phone number with someone you trust”), rather than vague privacy rules (e.g., “do not share your phone number”) [37]. Parents’ interview results from our study also suggest that context-based privacy education and practices may be effective for autistic children.

Researchers have explored playful, context-based approaches for teaching various skills to autistic children through simulated 2D or 3D mixed-reality scenarios [12, 39]. For instance, Join-In Suite promotes autistic children’s social collaboration skills through learning different social vignettes and experiencing simulated social problems [22]. More recently, RedCapes, a serious game adapted from Little Red Riding Hood, teaches autistic children to recognize privacy risks across everyday scenarios such as school, home, public spaces, and hospitals [70]. Findings showed improvements in children’s ability to identify privacy-relevant information and understand appropriate disclosure, though challenges remained in generalizing concepts to familiar contexts.

However, existing privacy education games for autistic children remain limited in scope. RedCapes, for example, focuses primarily on physical privacy and personal information in offline contexts, leaving digital privacy largely unaddressed. Future work should explore broader privacy domains (e.g., online privacy, data collection practices, and digital footprints) maintaining the contextual, playful approach that proves effective for autistic learners in *in-situ* educational interventions.

5.4.3 Promoting privacy education for parents. Findings reveal participants’ interests in engaging in privacy education contexts so they could help their children better understand privacy-related knowledge and social contexts, reinforcing lessons and helping their children apply and strengthen what they learned through real-life practices (see Section 4.3.2). Moreover, given parents’ critical roles in managing their privacy (see Section 4.1.1), future research and applications should consider privacy education a collaborative effort among researchers/designers, autistic children, and their parents. More specifically, future work could include learning objectives for parents’ involvement to improve their privacy literacy (i.e., helping them identify potential privacy risks, equipping them with effective protection strategies, and correcting parents’ potential misunderstandings about privacy). In addition, future privacy research and interventions developed for autistic children need to emphasize and assess their parents’ roles in privacy education for autistic children and further explore the interactions between autistic children and their parents through defining shared goals and collaborative tasks.

5.5 Limitations

This study has several limitations. First, this study reflects parental rather than autistic individuals’ perspectives. Autistic children may experience and interpret privacy and identity disclosure in ways that differ from their parents’ views. Future research could engage autistic adolescents or adults to reflect on their childhood disclosure experiences and examine their privacy practices. Second, recruiting participants was challenging, as some parents were reluctant to discuss sensitive experiences with unfamiliar researchers. Although our sample was small (14 participants), it offers valuable insights given the sensitivity of the topic. Despite using follow-up questions and probing techniques to encourage openness, some parents remained cautious. Our findings likely capture *frontstage* narratives, accounts parents felt comfortable sharing, while their *backstage* privacy work, involving more private moral and emotional negotiations, was only partially accessible. Moreover, the participants in our study were mostly mothers (only two fathers participated) of autistic children, whose children were mostly boys. This imbalance may reflect both gendered caregiving roles, mothers often serving as primary caregivers with more flexible schedules, and the broader gender distribution of autism diagnoses in China [62]. However, this focus may unintentionally underrepresent the experiences of autistic girls. Future research could further explore a more diverse and inclusive demographic of autistic children and their family caregivers to better understand how privacy experiences and disclosure practices may vary across gender and family relationships.

6 Conclusion

This study examined how Chinese parents of autistic children navigate privacy across home, school, and digital environments. Drawing on interviews with 14 parents, we showed that privacy in this context is understood not simply as individual control over personal information, but as a relational and moral responsibility shaped by cultural expectations, stigma, and hopes for children’s social belonging. Parents engaged in ongoing privacy work to protect their children from discrimination, maintain family dignity, and secure access to educational and social resources. At the same time, their efforts were challenged by infrastructural vulnerabilities in digital platforms, inconsistent privacy norms across family members, and children’s difficulties in recognizing and managing private information. Our findings highlight that privacy is an ongoing, relational effort embedded in cultural norms of face, collective reputation, and interdependent family roles. This work provides a culturally grounded account of how parents of autistic children protect privacy within everyday interactions, showing how decisions about disclosure are shaped by cultural norms, social expectations, and institutional infrastructures in China. Building on these insights, we call for designing privacy-supportive tools that enable parents to seek help and community without compromising anonymity, as well as context-based privacy education that equips autistic children to understand and practice privacy in everyday situations. Overall, this study contributes to the growing body of HCI research by illuminating how parents of autistic children navigate disclosure and protection within cultural, familial, and institutional conditions in China, in turn identifying opportunities for privacy-supportive tools that better align with families’ lived needs and social contexts.

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A Appendix: Interview Questions

A.1 Introduction

Thanks for meeting us today! Today we're going to talk to you about you and your children's, daily activities. There is no right or wrong answer, we just want to know what you think. If you don't want to answer a question, just let me know and we can stop right there. Do you have any questions before we start? OK, let's get started!

- How old is your child and what grade level is he/she in?
- What is the average time you spend with your child each day?
- Do you have any challenges in caring for your child?
- What are some of the challenges your child faces in his/her daily life at home and at school?

A.2 Offline Activities

A.2.1 School Life.

- How does your child interact with other children and teachers at school?
- What are the topics of conversation between the child and other children?
- Does your child have any little secrets that he/she doesn't want others to know about?
- Do you have any impressions of your child sharing things about himself or family with others? Can you describe the situation?
- Have you ever told your children what they can and cannot tell or share with others?

A.2.2 Family Activities.

- How does your child interact with his/her family members?
- What topics does your child talk about with his/her family?
- Do you have any impressions of your child sharing some of his or her little secrets with the family? Can you describe the situation?
- Does your child have his/her own separate room? What does he/she do in it?
- Does your child have anything in the house that is exclusively his/her own? How does he/she treat them?
- Does your child have anything in the house that is exclusively his/her own?
- How do you handle your child's belongings?

A.3 Online Scenarios

A.3.1 Information Searching.

- Do you use search engines (such as Baidu) to search for information?
- Do you use search engines (such as Baidu) to search for information about your child?
- Do you need an account to log in to the search engine you use?
- Is this account personal to you or will it be shared with others?
- Do you know what phone data the search engine can access?
- If someone can see your search history, how do you feel?

- Do you think the search engine can know what you are doing on its application?
- Do you think the search engine collects information about your family? What kind of information it may collect?
- Do you take any measures to prevent your information from being collected?
- Do you think the search engine will know about your child's autism diagnosis through your searching activities?
- What do you think are the potential benefits you might derive from such information collection?
- Do you have any concerns about such a thing?

A.3.2 Autism-Related Information Communication.

- Where do you get information that can help your child?
- How did you find this platform?
- How many users are using this platform?
- Have you ever shared information about your child on that platform to get advice or help others? Why?
- Have others did that? What's your opinion about it?
- What do you think are the benefits of such a platform?
- Do you have any concerns about such a platform?

A.3.3 Children's Online Social Interactions.

- Does your child interact with others online? With whom?
- How often has your child chatted online in the past two weeks?
- What apps do your children usually use?
- Do you know what are the topics of conversation?
- Have you ever intervened in your child's online social activities? Can you share this experience with us?
- Do you make any rules for your child when he/she social online? Why do you make these rules?
- Does your child share photos online?
- What kinds of photos does your child usually like to share with others?
- Does your child ask your permission or advice before sharing photos?
- Are there any photos that your child will not share? Why?
- What are your thoughts if someone else shares a photo of your child on a social media platform without your permission (the photo was taken by that person)?
- Do you make any rules for your child when he/she shares photos on the internet? Why do you make these rules?

A.4 Closing Questions

As you may have noticed, many of the questions we asked today actually involve privacy. We would like you to describe your thoughts about your family and your child's personal privacy.

- Do you think children have their own privacy?
- Are there any situations in your daily life where your family or your child's privacy is at risk of being violated?
- What measures have you taken to protect your family's and your child's privacy?
- What are your expectations about your family's privacy?
- Have others did that? What's your opinion about it?
- What do you think are the benefits of such a platform?
- Do you have any concerns about such a platform?